SACHIN: You did indeed, but despite his efforts, my batting average for the series was 76, with scores of 88, 103 and 90 in the three Test matches, and I was in fact nominated Player of the Series. I would love to have that average right through my career.

We won the series 1–0, a result that gave us considerable confidence as we looked forward to the return tour of England the following summer. It looked likely to be an enthralling series.

Some thoughts on batting

It was in the early stages of the 2002 tour of England that I first gave a masterclass. It was at the Rose Bowl, where we were playing a warm-up game against Hampshire, and it was organized by Mark Nicholas for Channel 4 television. I enjoyed talking to a group of youngsters about the basics of batting, including how to grip the bat.

People have often commented on my own grip, which is very low down on the handle. It all goes back to when I started playing cricket when I was eleven with my brother Ajit, who is ten years older. As I didn't have a bat of my own, I had to use Ajit's full-size bat and the only way I could cope with the weight at that age was to hold the bat right at the bottom of the handle. Some coaches suggested changing my grip, and I did experiment, but it never felt right. I had got used to feeling the end of the handle pressing against the inside of my forearm and if I gripped the bat further up I didn't have that, and batting just didn't feel natural.

That's not to say that my technique didn't change at all, though. Throughout my career, I was always looking to improve and constantly tried new things to cope with different situations. My backlift changed significantly over the years, for example. I used a pretty heavy bat and I was sometimes encouraged to move to a lighter one. Again, I did try but I never felt comfortable, as my whole bat swing depended on that weight. When I was hitting a drive, I needed the weight to generate the power. It was all to do with the timing. To me the bat should be an extension of your arm, and if you've reached the stage where it's become an extension of your arm, why do you need to change?

What mattered to me most when I was batting was feeling comfortable. As long as I felt comfortable, it didn't matter where I was playing or who I was playing against. If you make technical adjustments, such as moving to a lighter bat, to cope with different conditions, there's